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## Introduction

30 years after the last referendum held about Quebec's sovereignty, an interesting phenomenon has grabbed the media's attention in the province: a seemingly unpredicted rise of separatism in the youth of the province (Cheung & Rubertucci, 2025). Understanding the process behind what might drive this stronger identification to the Quebec identity, especially in a context so different from the last peaks of the movement, can help shed light on the potential of this new movement in terms of political change, its strength and its durability. Indeed, if the first waves of separatism happened in a time where there were still forms of structural inequality between the French speaking Québécois and the anglophones, the most evident economic forms of this inequality disappeared after 1995 (Béland et al., 2010). And so have the political tensions which led to a change in the sources of animosity (Rocher, 2023). In this current context, it is relevant to study the Quebec identity and what strengthens it, while most focus is shed on the political movement. After all, Quebec separatism would not be a thing without identification to start with. Following socio-psychological explanations, namely Bougie 's cultural narrative and entitativity explanation (Bougie et al., 2011), I seek to explain the attachment to Quebec identity through a powerful yet still unexplored theoretical framework in this case, the Uncertainty-Identity Theory, developed by Hogg (2007). The model focuses on uncertainty as the starting point in a process that leads individuals to identify stronger to groups. This paper therefore asks: "How do feelings of uncertainty influence the strength of national identity in Quebec?". Following Hogg's theory, I argue that all types of uncertainty lead individuals to seek out highly entitative groups to reduce their uncertainty. Quebec being a highly entitative group in respect to Campbell's (1958) classic criteria of entitativity, uncertainty should strengthen the identification of individuals to which the Quebec identity is accessible. As to the source of this uncertainty, I argue even though the structural unfairness/discrimination that divided French speakers and anglophones in the past has now disappeared, perceived discrimination or unfairness is a very strong predictor of Quebec identity, and that older people, having lived through more concrete forms of inequality, are more likely to perceive inequality than young people. In the first part of this paper, the theoretical model of my argument will be discussed, after which the methods will be presented. The third part will consist in an analysis of the results of data analysis. Finally, a discussion including the limits of the paper followed by a conclusion will constitute the last parts of this paper.

## Theory & Literature Review

Hogg's Uncertainty-Identity Theory (UIT) (2007) is the pilar of the model presented in this article. Its starting point is Social-Identity Theory (SIT), developed by Tajfel (1982). According to Tajfel, individuals define themselves through their group memberships and then seek a positive and distinctive social identity which they obtain by positively comparing themselves to other groups. SIT has been applied to the Quebec case before, namely by Thomson (1995). In his work, Thomson argues that the French language is the ultimate boundary through which the Québécois ingroup both defines itself and distinguishes itself from anglophones and the rest of Canada (Thomson, 1995: 71-82). The issue with Social-Identity Theory is that it fails to explain precisely when and why some identities become more salient. For example, it could not explain the recent rise in interest for Quebec identity and culture in young people, as discussed in the introduction. That is where Hogg's UIT is particularly interesting. The starting point of UIT is that individuals can and will feel uncertain about different aspects of their lives. He defines uncertainty as practically any situation that leads an individual to question his value, his place in the world that surrounds him (Hogg, 2009: 222). He argues that to reduce this anxiety provoking uncertainty, the individual will seek an accessible, well-defined and highly entitative group to identify with, and

then enters the *depersonalization* process (Hogg, 2007). In this process, the individual gives himself attributes from the group he identifies with, in a way that allows them to know how to act and perceive themselves, which reduces uncertainty (Hogg, 2007: 80). The great aspect of this theory is that it explains, through uncertainty, why some identities are more salient than others. Hogg also mentions that if uncertainty often comes from doubting our own characteristics, the possibility that uncertainty arises from doubt about the group's attributes and characteristics must not be rejected, because this do, can lead to self-uncertainty (uncertainty about oneself) (Hogg, 2007: 98).

Even if the literature has never explicitly applied UIT to the Quebec case, a lot of models and theories provide a basis for understanding the possible sources of uncertainty in the Quebec case. The literature on Quebec identity has long been strongly tied with the study of support for independence. The classic literature on the matter was developed between the mid-1970s and the 2000s. The period is characterized by the two referendums on Quebec sovereignty (1980 and 1995) and the political crisis led by constitutional issues on negotiating Quebec's status within Canada (Watts, 1991). The literature is dominated by two main theoretical approaches: economics inspired rational theoretical approach, such as Nadeau et al.'s Risk-Taking model (Nadeau et al., 1999) and structural models, such as Pinard's grievances model (Mendelsohn, 2003). In his hybrid between the two theories, Mendelsohn provides an interesting foundation to understand the support for independence. He argues that an individual will vote in favor of independence if he has grievances, such as feeling dominated or disrespected as a French-speaking Québécois. That is, only if he judges that the benefits of independence will be worth more than the costs (Mendelsohn, 2003). In the model, *grievances* include the feeling of being dominated, disrespected as French speaking Québécois, and *benefits* can mean anything the individual judges he will get out of Quebec becoming independent (economic or cultural) (Mendelsohn, 2003). Tying this to UIT, grievances can be understood as the source of uncertainty, as feelings of being dominated, discriminated or treated unfairly have been proven to create internal conflicts between identities (Fleischmann et al., 2019), which makes the individual doubt his own attributes, which is what Hogg refers to as "self-uncertainty" (Hogg, 2007). The perceived benefits described by Nadeau et al., can be tied to positive distinctiveness, which is a part of SIT and UIT. In the eyes of the individual, Quebec being independent could mean a more positively distinct identity if it meant becoming a majority. The limitations of the classic models on Quebec support for independence is its reliance on the context. As previously mentioned, the models were developed in a very specific time, with a very specific political climate and structure. The structural economic gap between anglophones and francophones has disappeared in 1995, after the exile of anglophone economic elites (Béland et al., 2010). It is therefore to be expected that not only the grievances have shifted since then, but also the perceived benefits of independence. The other limit of these models is their starting point. They seem to disregard the identity formation process that logically precedes the choice of supporting independence. In summary, the classic models on support of Quebec independence provide us with a basic understanding of the role of grievances as a motor of identification to Quebec, and the benefits perceived as positive distinction.

The idea that the context transforms Quebec identity is deeply confirmed by the literature, particularly in the field of historical sociology. Indeed, the political and cultural context have transformed the way sociologists conceptualize the Quebec identity. For example, at the beginning of the British colonization, Quebecers were considered as an ethno-religious minority (French Catholicism distinguished them from British Protestantism) (Fournier, 2001). Later, under the structural domination by anglophone elites, they were considered as an ethno-linguistic

minority. This is well illustrated by the report on British North America sent by Lord Durham to the British Parliament in 1839, where he says that the French Canadians are nothing but the "*remnants of an ancient civilization* […] *they can see no hope for their nationality"* and suggest that the only possibility for the French Canadians is to be assimilated to an English confederacy (American or British) (Durham, 1839 : 93 ; Fournier, 2001). It is not coincidentally that during this period, the Quebec identity started revolving around the fear of survival, and that narrative will remain relevant for a long time. As Bougie et al. (2011) show, the Québécois collective identity is shaped by historical narratives that highlight vulnerability, such as the Conquest or threats to cultural survival. Similarly, Abulof argues that "small peoples", category in which he puts the Québécois, often experience existential uncertainty regarding their cultural survival (Abulof, 2009). However, as Fournier (2001) also points out, the Quebec identity, passed 1995, becomes a dominant, majority identity. This explains what Rocher (2023), described as a shift in the animosity that fuels Quebec identity. Indeed, as the Canadian and anglophone economic and political elites disappeared from the province, the animosities shifted towards internal issues such as language protection and secularism (Rocher, 2023). These sources of animosity, however, can not logically create the same amount of uncertainty as the previous context did. Indeed, perceptions of discrimination or unfair treatment have been proven to lead to identification to the minority (Fleischman et al., 2019), which is explainable through UIT. However, as unfairness and structural inequality have faded, what type of uncertainty can explain the identification to Quebec? Hogg's theory defines uncertainty as "*refers to any aspect of self that one is uncertain of and argues that group identification can be a powerful resolution of uncertainty even about personal aspects of self"* (Hogg, 2009: 222). I argue that, as the unfairness and structural inequality faded out, personal uncertainty about oneself became a stronger predictor of Quebec identity amongst young people, who haven't lived through the unfairness, while perceptions of unfairness remain an important predictor, particularly among older people, who have lived through the unfairness which negatively influences the expectancy of justice (Maltese et al., 2016). As for people who haven't lived through the unfairness, UIT explains that individuals can also reduce self-uncertainty, that is, uncertainty about personal attributes and place in the world, by identifying to a highly entitative, well-defined and accessible group (Hogg, 2007).

In his definition of entitativity, Hogg refers to Campbell's foundational work on entitativity (1958). It defines entitativity as the degree to which a group resembles an entity. Campbell evaluates entitativity with the following criteria: common fate, similarity, proximity, closed boundaries and multiple confirmations (Campbell, 1958). Common fate refers to the group sharing a common history and destiny. Bougie et al., (2011), find that the identity of French speaking Quebecois has been tied to negative historical events, through a process of collective relative deprivation creating the impression of a common fate. As for similarity, Quebec has a distinct cultural identity, characterized by social markers such as language and religion (Thomson, 1995). For proximity, Quebec is, as the criteria requires, delimitated territorially, which consolidates the group identity (Thomson, 1995; Bougie et al., 2011). Highly entitative groups also often have clear boundaries and non-ambiguous criteria of who belongs and who doesn't. The Quebec nationalism is historically founded upon the building of borders between "us" and "the other", with language as a main delimitation (Rocher, 2023). As for the last criteria, "multiple confirmations" refers to the multiplicity of processes that confirms their boundaries and structure. In this case, the previously mentioned criteria are repeated through political institutions (Thomson, 1995) as well as the collective perceptions and narratives (Bougie et al., 2011).

To summarize, classic literature identifies the role of grievances and perceived unfairness in support for independence and historical sociology documents the history of the boundaries of Quebec identity, there is a gap in explaining why the identity becomes more salient periods of history. While Thomson has used SIT to argue the role of language in the positive distinctiveness

process (1995), an essential next step is to use Hogg's UIT. With UIT, I suggest that the grievances, the sources of collective relative deprivation identified by the previous literature is a source of uncertainty, particularly in older people, who have lived through this uncertainty, and self-uncertainty about the individual's own perception of himself, all activate the search for a well-defined, highly entitative group to reduce this uncertainty. As shown above, Quebec constitutes a highly entitative group, which suggests that uncertainty should be a predictor of Quebec identity. This is shown in the hypotheses presented below.

## Hypotheses

**H1:** French speaking Quebecois individuals with higher uncertainty will identify more strongly to the Quebec identity.
**H2:** Perceived unfairness or discrimination is a strong predictor of Quebec identity.
**H2a:** Perceived unfairness or discrimination will be more common among older people.

## Research design

The data used in this paper comes from the 2021 edition of *Canadian Election* Studies. It is one of the most comprehensive surveys for the study of political attitudes in Canada. CES 2021 is composed by two blocks: the *Campaign-Period Survey* (CPS) and a *Post-Election Survey* (PES). Administered in three waves, the survey includes a final sample of 20 968 respondents. It was administered between the 17th of august to the 19th of September 2021. The Post-Election Survey was held between the 23rd of September to the 4th of October of the same year, totalizing 15 069 respondents. For the purposes of this paper, I created a subsample including only French speaking Québécois (as language constitutes the main characteristic of Quebec identity according to the literature). The subsample includes 5798 observations.

The variables chosen to operationalize the first hypothesis come from the *Campaign-Period Survey*. To measure uncertainty (the IV), I chose multiple variables. Firstly, to measure self-related uncertainty, I chose *cps21_govt_confusing:* Ordinal variable measuring on a scale from 1 to 4 the respondent`s answer to: "*Sometimes, politics and government seem so complicated that a person like me can't really understand what's going on*". I also chose *to cps21_govt_say*, another ordinal variable measuring on a scale from 1-4 the respondent's answer to "*People like me don't have any say about what the government does*". This relates to self-uncertainty, as the concept refers to the individual's conception of themselves. The higher the answer is, the more uncertain the individual is about his place and impact on his environment. To measure more economic related uncertainty, *cps21_own_fin_future* and *cps_21_own_fin_retro* measure the individual's feeling about his financial situation (respectively for the next year and over the past year) via an ordinal variable from 1) Better to 3) Worse. Here, the higher the answer, the higher the economic uncertainty is. For the first hypothesis, the Quebec identity was measured through the support for Quebec independence (*cps21_quebec_sov*), which logically reveals a stronger identification to Quebec than to Canada. The variable is ordinal, going from 1) Very favourable to 4) very opposed. If the hypothesis is right, the coefficients will therefore be negative.

For the second hypothesis, the variable *pes21_prov_treatment* is ordinal, and asks respondents if they think the federal government treats their problem 1) Better, 2) Worse or 3) The same as the other provinces. For this variable, the interest is only towards the 2) worse response and so recoding will be necessary to make it a binary variable. The dependent variable is once again the support Quebec independence (*cps21_quebec_sov*). For H2A, the variables are

*pes21_prov_treatment* and *cps21_yob*, the latter, contrary to what its name indicates, measures the age and not the year of birth.

The first step of the analysis is to create a subsample that includes only respondents that 1) live in Quebec now of answering the survey and 2) speak French. This filtering is coherent with the research, as the focus is on Quebecois, who are likely to identify with Quebec identity, characterized by language (Thomson, 1995). The second step is to filter out non-answered and "Don't know" options to make the variables truly ordinal. Disregarding this step might lead to biased measures of uncertainty. The third step is to recode the *pes21_prov_treatment* to make it binary. The first regression is an OLS, using education as a control variable since it has probably an impact on the individual's perception of understanding politics. It is essential to test whether uncertainty even influences identity. The second regression (H2) is a simple regression testing whether the feeling that the federal government treats Quebec unfairly has an impact on Quebec identity. The third regression is another OLS between the respondent's age and the perception of Quebec being mistreated by the federal government. The two last regressions are crucial to understand whether unfairness indeed creates uncertainty resulting in stronger identification.

## Results

**Linear Regression : Perception of unfairness**

| | cps21_quebec_sov |
|---|---|
| pes21_prov_treatment | 0.119*** |
| | (0.023) |
| cps21_education | 0.013 |
| | (0.010) |
| Constant | 2.196*** |
| | (0.102) |
| *N* | 3,733 |
| $R^2$ | 0.007 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.007 |
| Residual Std. Error | 1.148 (df = 3730) |
| F Statistic | 13.605*** (df = 2; 3730) |
| *Notes:* | ***Significant at the 1 percent level. |
| | **Significant at the 5 percent level. |

**Linear Regression : Age**

| | pes21_prov_treatment |
|---|---|
| cps21_yob | 0.002** |
| | (0.001) |
| cps21_education | -0.017** |
| | (0.007) |
| Constant | 2.550*** |
| | (0.067) |
| *N* | 3,733 |
| $R^2$ | 0.003 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.002 |
| Residual Std. Error | 0.809 (df = 3730) |
| F Statistic | 5.355*** (df = 2; 3730) |
| *Notes:* | ***Significant at the 1 percent level. |
| | **Significant at the 5 percent level. |
| | *Significant at the 10 percent level. |

The regression shown on Table 1 shows mixed results concerning Uncertainty-Identity theory. The future financial uncertainty variable is associated with a stronger support of Quebec independence. This supports the hypothesis according to which uncertainty motivates the search for identification to a highly entitative group like Quebec. However, the variables measuring more political personal forms of uncertainty are positively associated to the opposition to independence, going against the predicted outcome. Education and past financial uncertainty do not have any significant effect on support for independence.

These results seem to point out some of the limitations resulting from the variables available.

The second regression, shown on Table 2, shows that the perception that the federal government treats Quebec unfairly increases the opposition to independence, which directly contradicts the second hypothesis based on UIT. This result suggests that the variable pes21_prov_treatment might be more a measure of judgment towards the federal government rather than a measure of feeling discriminated or treated unfairly as a Quebecois. These results indicate that in 2021, institutional unfairness didn't constitute a pertinent source of uncertainty in the province. The third regression shows that the age is positively associated with perception of an unfair treatment of Quebec by the federal government. This goes along with the H2a hypothesis according to which older individuals perceive more unfair treatment by the federal government. This suggests that indeed, the individuals that lived under the structural and economic inequalities between French speaking Quebecois have a stronger tendency to perceive unfairness even if the context is widely different today. However, the coefficient is not very strong, which indicates a milder effect than expected.

**Linear Regression : Quebec Sovereignty Support**

| | Quebec Sovereignty |
|---|---|
| cps21_govt_confusing | 0.114*** |
| | (0.019) |
| cps21_govt_say | 0.101*** |
| | (0.017) |
| cps21_own_fin_future | -0.125*** |
| | (0.025) |
| cps21_own_fin_retro | -0.033 |
| | (0.026) |
| cps21_education | 0.014 |
| | (0.009) |
| Constant | 2.297*** |
| | (0.113) |
| *N* | 5,314 |
| $R^2$ | 0.022 |
| Adjusted $R^2$ | 0.021 |
| Residual Std. Error | 1.134 (df = 5308) |
| F Statistic | 24.150*** (df = 5; 5308) |
| *Notes:* | ***Significant at the 1 percent level. |
| | **Significant at the 5 percent level. |
| | *Significant at the 10 percent level. |

To summarize, the results of the data analysis do not confirm most of our hypotheses. Political personal forms of uncertainty, as well as past economic uncertainty do not seem to influence the identification to Quebec identity. However, future economic uncertainty about one's own financial situation seems to create a stronger identification to Quebec. The perception of unfair treatment, contrarily to what was expected in the second hypothesis only increases the opposition to independence rather than the support, which contradicts H2 completely. And finally, older individuals are slightly more likely to perceive unfair treatment by the federal government. This suggests that all forms of uncertainty do not play the same role in the identification process.

## Conclusion

This paper started with a very pertinent question in the current Quebec sociopolitical context: How do different forms of uncertainty affect the national identification to Quebec. While classic models were mostly based on structural grievances, constitutional tensions and benefits – costs calculations, these approaches failed to explain fully the dynamics of the Quebec identity formation, particularly amongst those whose formative years weren't characterized by the same structural and economic inequalities as previous generations. The goal of this paper was therefore to analyze the Quebec identity through a yet unexplored theoretical lens: the Uncertainty Identity Theory. Our findings contribute to the field by revealing that all forms of uncertainty do not play the same role in the depersonalization process Hogg describes. In coherence with UIT, economic uncertainty about the future seems to be a clear motor for support of independence, suggesting that uncertainty about one's one status can lead him to seek uncertainty-reduction in the highly entitative group that is Quebec. However, strong limitations must be considered. First and foremost, concerning the variables. If the strength of a survey like CES is its size, the variables available were not the best at measuring the different concepts. First, measuring identity via support for independence is not ideal, as, like shown by Mendelsohn (2003), benefits – cost is the strongest predictor of support for independence. In other words, an individual might have a huge identification to Quebec and still might not be in support of independence at the time of the survey, particularly the survey was taken close to COVID-19 lockdowns. Secondly, the variables also did not measure uncertainty or perception of unfairness very precisely. Stronger survey question could include directly asking the respondents more personal question, about their social life, and about if they feel less advantaged than others. Finally, another limitation is the data availability. If 2021 is the latest available dataset, it was in a very specific context, with COVID-19, where Quebec culture and independence did not have the attention, it has today in the media. Considering this, the same study with updated variables and 2025 data would be ideal to explore further the research question. Despite the limitation, the research brings a theoretical contribution to the field : uncertainty is a significant factor in Quebec identification. In the future, new research could compare different periods of times and types of uncertainty.

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